

PHILLIP ADAMS has just brought six broad-brimmed hats from Akubra. Three are authentic Outback Bryan Brown dung khaki but three are black.

Mr Adams in black hat, black leather jacket, black trousers and black boots, standing beside his red Ferrari, is a sight to be cherished. A distinguished Mexican gangster on his way to Acapulco? A representative of Fidel Castro, do you think? No, his expression is a little too benign, too whimsical for that. Perhaps Peter Ustinov playing Clint Eastwood.

He is somewhat miffed that he is continually on lists of Australia's worst-dressed males. Last time he was just beaten out of first place by Norm Gallagher. Jack Thompson, who had a shop in Sydney that made male clothing, gave him that leather jacket and he has improved out of sight. There have been several occasions recently when he has worn black tie and evening jacket, looking utterly svelte.

One remembers that celebrated occasion when an Adams production was the first feature movie to score an AFI award. Phillip didn't own a suit, let alone a tie. The scene was the National Library in Canberra. The Prime Minister, John Gorton, had to come to his rescue.

He is still devoted to the black skivvy, the perfect, most utterly useful garment. He has a dilly bag, a magic hold-all, which never leaves him. It contains razor, toothbrush, alarm clock, pills, 800 credit cards, micro tape-recorder and, ah yes, black skivvies. When you are in Sydney on Monday, Auckland on Tuesday, Perth on Wednesday and defying God in Adelaide on Thursday, a spare black skivvy is your answer to non-existent prayers.

The brief was to find out about the evolving Adams; what does he really do? He appears to know everybody; great names roll off his tongue: Bob, Kerry, Lionel, Neville, Gough, Andrew, Patrick, John ... the suspicion is that the man behind the scenes, the character who really runs this country, is Phillip Adams.

He does it in his spare time between

2 am and 4 am. In recent weeks there has been some acid flowing back and forth. He has been accused of verbal diarrhoea, of being unfunny and, good grief, perhaps even going ultra conservative. He has been attacked by Terry McCrann on the business pages of *The Age*, assaulted by Anthony McAdam and even his old mate, Frank Hardy, has had a go.

Much of the counter artillery came when Adams attacked Brian Toohey of *The National Times*. "I very rarely attack people," said Adams. "I can't think of the last time I attacked an individual. I don't do that, apart from Toohey. That's because he's attacking others without sense or judgment."

"I suppose I've got to know a lot of the victims of what Patrick Cook calls vendetta journalism. I know Neville Wran. He's not a crook. He may be incompetent but he's not a crook. Yet every journalist *knows* he's a crook. They *know* there's a Swiss bank account. It's bullshit."

"I know Lionel Murphy and I like the bloke. I don't agree with Kerry Packer about anything but I like him as a friend. I know what he does. He didn't murder anyone. He doesn't sell drugs and he is not Mr Big of Australian crime. He's got a pathological gambling urge, which he acknowledges. I just keep seeing people whom the press in a sort of manic energy has done over and I know it's not true. That throws you."

If Adams hands it out, is he sensitive, thin-skinned, when assaulted in return? Well, yes, sometimes, particularly when the attack seems inexplicable. Terry McCrann's piece was on the business page, of all places. Normally it is a part of the paper he never visits.

"The thing I found offensive," he said, "was the first paragraph. The only way those blokes can get at me is the advertising. You know, ad man with irreversible brain damage. They don't say that about Donald Horne. They don't say it about Peter Carey."

"Donald Horne was creative director of a multi-national advertising agency for 15 years. Peter Carey owns an agency. Funny thing, in my generation there was nowhere else to work. Bruce Petty was in it too. There's hardly anyone who didn't

MICHAEL RAYNER

THE PHILLIP ADAMS INDUSTRY

By KEITH DUNSTAN

